TRUMP MANAGEMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

TRUMP MANAGEMENT LESSON

When you play a suit contract the first, and usually most important, decision you need to make is whether to start by pulling trumps. Fortunately there is a rule for you to follow which is never wrong.

YOU SHOULD ALWAYS PULL TRUMPS IMMEDIATELY -
EXCEPT FOR THOSE TIMES WHEN YOU SHOULDN'T

This lesson and the Deals that go with it will show you those times.

Always pull trumps immediately:

The contract is 4♥ and West leads the ♠J.

♠ 7 3
♥ A J 9 4 2
♦ 9 6 4
♣ Q J 10



♠ A K Q
♥ K Q 10 5 3
♦ 8 7 3
♣ K 3

You have 3 losers in ♦s and 1 in ♣s.

You are ecstatic that West didn't lead a minor suit so you play your 3 high ♠s and discard a ♦ from dummy on the third one. Unfortunately East ruffs the ♠ and the defense takes their **2** ♦ tricks plus the ♣A.

This is a really basic example but I'll bet we have all seen it happen. Of course you should win the first trick, **THEN PULL TRUMPS**, then run the ♠s for the discard.

Too easy you say, and you are right. Probably everybody reading this would have pulled trumps.

Have you ever had someone, (your partner?), tell you that they couldn't pull trumps because the suit was too weak? Bad reasoning; with weak trumps and strong side suits you should lead trumps early and often.

The contract is 4♠ and West leads the ♣8.

♠ 7 4 3 2
♥ A K Q
♦ J 10 9
♣ K J 9



♠ 9 8 6 5
♥ J 10 9
♦ A K Q
♣ A Q 10

You have no losers in any suit except trumps.

And if the trumps split 3-2 you can HOPE to lose only 3 tricks there. So you should win the first trick and lead a trump - which you will lose. Win the next trick and play another trump - which you will lose. Win the next trick and lose one more trump if you like, it doesn't matter at this point.

But think what could happen if you didn't play on trumps at every opportunity. You could be leading high side suit cards and East ruffs a ♣ with the ♠10. Then West ruffs a ♥ with the ♠J. And East ruffs with the ♠Q, and West ruffs with the ♠K and somebody still has the ♠A. In other words the defenders had 5 high trumps and you let them make them all individually.

Point made.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you need to ruff tricks in dummy:

The contract is 6♦ and West leads the ♦5.

♠ 8 5
♥ 9 6 5 2
♦ 7 4
♣ A K 7 4 2



♠ A K 4 3
♥ A K 3
♦ A K Q J 9
♣ 5

You have 2 losers in ♠s and 1 in ♥s.
You can pull trumps, then discard the ♥ loser on dummy's high ♣, but you will still be left with the 2 ♠s.

A better play is delay pulling trumps. Play the ♠ A K 4, ruffing the ♠4 with dummy's last trump. Then play a ♥ to your hand and now pull trumps.

You will still have 1 ♠ loser at the end but you will make the contract.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you need the trump suit for entries:

The contract is 6♠ and West leads the ♣K.

♠ K Q 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ 7 3 2
♣ 8 5 4 2



♠ A J 10 9 6 4
♥ A K
♦ A Q J
♣ A 7

With a sure ♣ loser you need to have the ♦ finesse.

Suppose trumps split 3-1 (probable) and you pull them ending in dummy. You can then take the ♦ finesse but even when it wins you are doomed because you cannot repeat it.

Instead win the first trick and play ♠A then small to dummy's ♠Q. Now finesse the ♦ successfully and return to the ♠K, pulling the last trump. Finesse the ♦ once more and claim.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you can't afford to lose the lead yet:

Perhaps the reason you can't afford to lose the lead yet is that you need to discard a loser quickly. The contract is 5♣ and West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ A 8
♣ Q 6 5 4 3



♠ A 4
♥ A 7 2
♦ K 5 4
♣ K J 9 8 7

The ♥ lead has exposed your 2 ♥ losers early.

You can ruff the small ♦ in dummy, but you cannot avoid losing the Ace of trumps. If you lead a ♣ now the defenders will grab their ♣A and immediately cash their 2 ♥ tricks.

So before playing a trump you play 3 ♠s, discarding a ♥ on dummy's third ♠. Only then is it safe to start pulling trumps.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you plan to play a cross-ruff:

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♦K.

♠ A
♥ Q J 9 7
♦ 9 8 7 5 3
♣ A 7 5



♠ 9 8 7 4 2
♥ A K 10 8
♦ A
♣ K 6 4

You can win your 4 side suit high cards, then alternate ruffing 4 ♠s in dummy and 4 ♦s in your hand.

One of the two keys to a cross-ruff is that you might not have enough winners if you play a round of trumps. In this deal, for example, you needed to make all 8 trumps individually; even one lead would have cost you two trumps for one winning trick.

The second key is that you must take any side-suit winners early. Here if you delay taking your ♣A and ♣K, one of the defenders might discard ♣s while you are playing the other suits and be able to ruff a ♣ winner late in the game.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you plan a dummy reversal:

A mistake made frequently by beginners is taking an early ruff in the long-trump hand. When you ruff in the short-trump hand it does two good things - it gives you an immediate winner and it also gives you an extra winner. When you ruff in the long-trump hand it gives you an immediate winner but it seldom gives you an extra trick.

Look at these three hands:

You are playing a ♥ contract and West leads the ♣ A K.

♠ K J 7 2
♥ K Q J
♦ 6 5 4 3 2
♣ 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ --
♣ 5 4 3

You can ruff 2 ♣s in dummy, the short-trump hand.

You will now make a total of 7 trump tricks, your 5 plus dummy's 2 ruffs.

Dummy's ruffs have actually gained you 2 tricks.

♠ K J 7
♥ K Q J
♦ 5 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ A 6
♣ 3

You can ruff the second ♣ in your hand, the long-trump hand.

You could even ruff dummy's last ♣ if you wanted to, but it wouldn't help you.

Because ruffing in your hand hasn't gained you any tricks, you still only get 5 trump tricks.

♠ K J
♥ K Q J
♦ 5 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 4 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ A 6
♣ 3

Ruff the second ♣ in your hand with the ♥A.
Play a ♥ to dummy's ♥J.
Ruff dummy's third ♣ in your hand.
Play a ♥ to dummy's ♥Q.
Ruff dummy's last ♣ with your last ♥.
Play a ♠ to dummy's ♠K.
Pull the opponents' last trump with dummy's ♥K, discarding your ♦ loser.
Overtake dummy's ♠J and your hand is good.
You actually made 6 trump tricks, 3 ruffs in your hand, and the 3 you pulled trumps with in dummy.

This is called a Dummy Reversal - because you used dummy's hand to pull trumps with, and took the ruffs in your own hand.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . the only trump left out is the master trump:

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♠A.

♠ 7 2
♥ K 5 4
♦ A 3
♣ A K Q J 10 9



♠ --
♥ A Q 7 6 2
♦ K 9 8 4 2
♣ 4 3 2

You ruff the ♠A and start pulling trumps with the ♥K, then the ♥A. West follows with the ♥3, then discards a ♠ on the second ♥ play so you will lose a trick to East's ♥ J 10 9 8.

You continue with the ♥Q which leaves you with just the ♥7 remaining in your hand while East has the master ♥J. Should you play the final trump?

Heck no! If you did there would be no stopping the avalanche of ♠s they would play! Instead, just start running dummy's ♣s until East gets frustrated and ruffs with the ♥J. Of course that now leaves you with a trump to stop the ♠s.

Despite the above suggestion, there is a time when you do not want to leave the master trump left out - when dummy has a long suit to run but has no outside entries. Change the previous hand around.

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♠A.

♠ 7 3 2
♥ 5 4
♦ 4 3
♣ A K Q J 10 9



♠ --
♥ A K Q 7 6 2
♦ A 9 8 4 2
♣ 3 2

You ruff the ♠A and start pulling trumps with the ♥A, then the ♥K. West follows with the ♥3, then discards a ♠ on the second ♥, so you will lose a trump trick to East's ♥ J 10 9 8.

Suppose you pull just one more trump with the ♥Q, then switch to ♣s, leaving East with the master ♥J. No good. East will ruff the second or third ♣ and even though you will have trump control you won't have a way back to dummy's good ♣s.

Instead you go ahead and force Easts ♥J out with your ♥7, still leaving you with the ♥6. If East plays a ♠ you can ruff with the last trump and then run the ♣ suit uninterrupted.

The last word:

This lesson and the practice Deals are mainly about the various times when you need to delay pulling trumps or perhaps not pull them at all. Don't let that give you the wrong idea though.

MOST OF THE TIME YOU SHOULD PULL TRUMPS IMMEDIATELY

. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



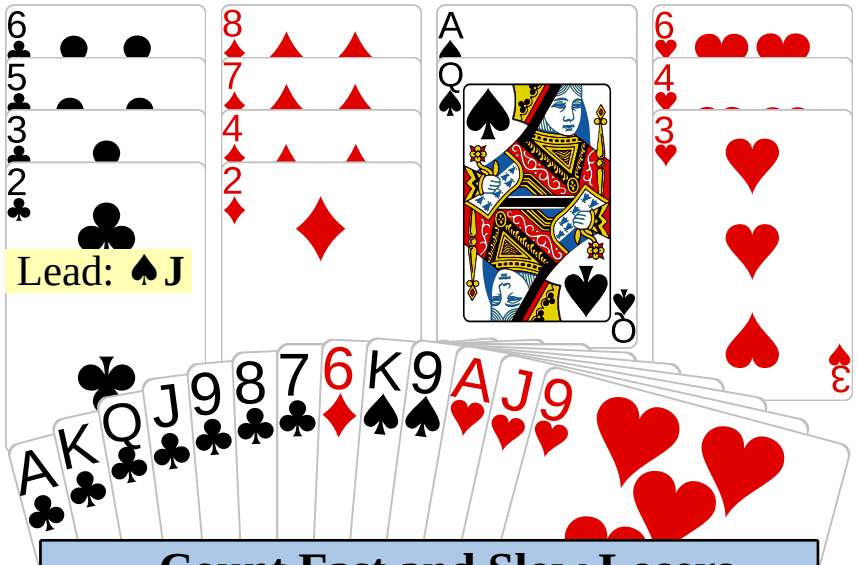
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **5♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 5♣
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠J

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣J

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K Q 9 7 4 ♥ 9 4 ♦ A 6 5 ♣ A K 6	
♠ 6 ♥ A 8 7 2 ♦ Q J 9 7 ♣ 10 8 5 2	N W E S	♠ J 10 5 3 ♥ Q J 10 3 ♦ 10 8 3 ♣ 9 3
	♠ A 8 2 ♥ K 6 5 ♦ K 4 2 ♣ Q J 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	1NT
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

North's 2♦ bid was New Minor Forcing, asking if South has 3 ♠s. South's 2♠ response said "Yes, I have." North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♥Q.

Losers: ♠ = ? ♥ = 2 ♦ = 1 ♣ = 0 Total = 3?

If the ♠s split 3-2 as they should, you have no ♠ loser and your plan will merely be to pull trumps and play winners. So what you do in that case is start figuring how to deal with a 4-1 split.

But first you should deal with the ♥K situation. Do you cover the ♥Q or not?

West plays the ♥2 and you the ♥4.

East continues with the ♥J.

Competent defenders do not underlead Aces at suit contracts. So if you are playing against a competent East you certainly don't cover. You play low on this trick and on the ♥J continuation, hoping West started with a doubleton ♥A. But he didn't, and he plays it on the third ♥ which you ruff.

Back to the Plan. Having ruffed the ♥ you are down to just 4 trumps in your hand. You play ♠A, ♠K, ♠Q, noting that West discards on the second round. Therefore East will get a trump trick.

But don't give it to him now! Leave East with his master trump and switch to ♣s. If East doesn't ruff at all you will run 4 ♣ tricks and discard your ♦ loser. If he does decide to ruff it will be with a trick you were going to lose anyway. You win his return, ruffing a ♥ with the last trump, and continue playing ♣ and ♦ winners.

You can't help losing two ♥s and one ♠.

But you don't have to lose anything else as long as you don't lose trump control. So leave the master trump with East and just cash your minor suit winners. Let East ruff whenever he wants to because that will establish your ♠9 to control any more ♥ leads. If he decides not to ruff at all then he can have the final trick with his high trump.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ J 7 6 2
♥ 10 7 4 3
♦ 9 5
♣ Q J 6

♠ 10 8
♥ K Q 8 6
♦ 8 7 2
♣ 9 7 5 3



♠ A K Q 9 5 3
♥ A
♦ A K 4
♣ A K 2

♠ 4
♥ J 9 5 2
♦ Q J 10 6 3
♣ 10 8 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♠	Pass
3♥	Pass	6♠	
All Pass			

6♠ by East
Lead: ♦Q

East is to play 6♠. South leads the ♦Q.

Losers: ♠ = 0 or 1 ♥ = 0 ♦ = 1 ♣ = 1 Total = 2 or 3

You probably do not have a trump loser because they will probably split 3-2. Still, a 4-1 split is certainly not out of the question.

But those two minor suit losers are definite **UNLESS** you can somehow get to dummy's ♥ K Q. Can you?

You win the ♦A.

Everyone follows.

North wins the ♠J.

Yes you can get to dummy, in the trump suit. Win the opening ♦ lead. Unblock the ♥A before touching trumps. Play a **SMALL** trump toward dummy. A defender will surely take his ♠J here, and play another ♦. Win that trick and play another small ♠. This one will get you into dummy. And by the way, South discards a ♦ so it turns out you were going to lose a trump in any case. Play dummy's ♥ K Q, discarding your two minor losers. Ruff a ♥ to return to your hand, pull trumps and claim.

As you can see you have a trump loser in addition to the small ♦ and ♣. By establishing the ♠ entry to dummy you can discard the ♦ and ♣.

You can see how it works if the trump suit DID split 3-2 as you would expect it to do. Even without a trump loser you will still go down 1 if you cannot take two discards on dummy's ♥s.

So you give up a trump trick and gain two ♥ tricks in return. What a deal.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q ♥ 6 4 3 ♦ 8 7 4 2 ♣ 6 5 3 2	
♠ J 10 8 6 3 ♥ Q 8 7 ♦ A Q 10 5 ♣ 4		♠ 7 5 4 2 ♥ K 10 5 2 ♦ K J 9 3 ♣ 10
	♠ K 9 ♥ A J 9 ♦ 6 ♣ A K Q J 9 8 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	4♣	Pass	5♣
All Pass			

5♣ by South
Lead: ♠J

South is to play 5♣. West leads the ♠J; dummy wins with the ♠Q, East plays the ♠2 and you the ♠9.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 3

You have no way to get rid of the Fast ♦ loser, but you might be able to eliminate one of the ♥ losers. If East holds either ♥ K 10 x or ♥ Q 10 x then a Deep Finesse would save one loser.

Should you pull trumps right away?

East plays low.

No, you cannot pull trumps yet. For the Deep Finesse to work you must lead twice from dummy. The only way to get into dummy twice is in the ♠ suit and one of those times must be at trick 1.

Win the first trick with dummy's ♠Q and play a ♥ to your ♥9. Assume West wins with the ♥K or ♥Q, and plays another ♠.

In dummy for the last time, play a ♥ to your ♥J and hope it wins.

As you can see, you must play ♥s twice from dummy in order to take the two finesses.

So you couldn't pull that one round of trumps because you couldn't waste either visit to dummy for anything other than the ♥ finesses.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

♠ A 9 8 4
♥ 4
♦ K Q 8 7 3
♣ 9 8 6

♠ K Q 3
♥ A K 9 7 5 3
♦ 6
♣ A 5 3



♠ 7 5 2
♥ 8 6
♦ A 9 4
♣ K Q J 10 2

♠ J 10 6
♥ Q J 10 2
♦ J 10 5 2
♣ 7 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♥	Pass	2♣	Pass
3♥	Pass	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♦K

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♦K.

Losers: ♠ = 2 ♥ = 1 or 2 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 or 4

In fact if trumps split 5-0 you could have 3 losers in the suit and a disaster. So we won't worry about that possibility. Since the most likely scenario is a 3-2 split you should plan on taking the ♥ A K, then driving out their master trump so you can run dummy's ♣s without somebody ruffing in.

Bad news. North discards a ♦ on the second ♥ lead. Time for a change in plans?

No change of plan is needed. South has 2 master trumps at this point but you still have ♥ 9 7 5 3. So use one of your little ones to drive out South's ♥J. He will probably force you to ruff a ♦, leaving you with ♥ 9 7. Use one of them to force out South's ♥Q. You still have a trump left to stop their ♦s, and as soon as you get the lead you can now run dummy's ♣ suit safely.

Suppose you had not driven out both of South's high trumps.

He would have ruffed the third ♣, before you could discard a ♠ loser from your hand. You would lose two trumps and two ♠s.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ J 9 7 5 4 2 ♥ A K ♦ 7 4 ♣ A 5 3	
♠ A K ♥ Q 10 9 4 ♦ J 10 8 2 ♣ Q 7 2	N W E S	♠ 8 ♥ 8 7 6 3 ♦ A 9 6 5 ♣ J 10 9 8
	♠ Q 10 6 3 ♥ J 5 2 ♦ K Q 3 ♣ K 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♣J

North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♣J.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

Unless the defense slips you are going to lose the Ace and King of trumps. And the ♦A is a Fast loser that they can take whenever they want to, so that means you must try to dispose of your ♣ loser. The only realistic hope is that East holds the ♦A and you can lead through it twice. So after you win your ♣A do you play a trump?

East plays low.

Dummy's ♦ honour holds the trick.

West plays low.

You are back in your hand.

East takes his ♦A.

As much as you'd like to get the trumps out you must work on the ♦s first. Because if you play even one trump the defense will win it and force out your remaining ♣ stopper before you have established a ♦ winner for the discard.

The correct procedure is to win the ♣A, and immediately play a ♦ to dummy's ♦Q, which holds the trick. Return to your hand with a ♥, and play another ♦ toward dummy. Suppose East takes his ♦A on this trick (otherwise you have no ♦ loser). He can now play a ♣ but you win with dummy's ♣K and discard your small ♣ on dummy's ♦K.

Only then do you lead trumps.

This is the perfect example of when you delay leading trumps.

When you need to do something else first - in this case, to establish a ♦s winner early.